When a sage first took Rama and Lakshmana to cleanse his hermitage of evil demons, little did they realize what that encounter presaged for their lives. It was their first brush with the forces of darkness, whose full powers they were far from grasping. Indeed, the very Maricha whom Lord Rama first neutralized came back in the form of a golden deer to deceive him in his later exile. Years later, in the initial phase of his banishment, he again pledged to protect the sages of Sharabhanga, perhaps unknowing of where this was to lead him.

There are so many instances of the future being decided by the juxtaposition of complicated events, be that the fate of the monkey-king Vali or the eagle-king Jatayu. A few like Maricha sense it but are still powerless to halt the course of destiny. In fact, the triggering event of King Dasaratha's boons is an example of an unintended decision leading to unanticipated consequences. This is also illustrated by the fact that Ravana does not even imagine the ultimate results of his abduction of Queen Sita.

In our modern world, we, too, live with uncertainties and turbulence. No amount of anticipation can prepare us fully. Yet, we must always assess, plan and be ready to respond. A sensible government, which has the welfare of its citizens at the centre of its thinking, will naturally put in place rules, regulations, mechanisms and practices for unforeseen contingencies. It would also constantly refine them based on experiences. That is exactly what has changed in the last decade, and if we look back, it is visible how much of a difference that has made to our common citizens.

DEALING WITH A GLOBALIZED EXISTENCE

A parallel example in public health during the same period is equally instructive. When the first wave of Covid hit India in 2020, we scrambled across the world to procure personal protective equipment (PPE), masks and ventilators and did so in a seller's market as the demand far exceeded supply. Ingredients for the pharmaceutical industry with escalating requirements were also greatly sought after. Even the inputs for vaccines came from tens of companies spread out in multiple nations, and they were subject to the primacy of local demands. Commerce by itself was not adequate in such circumstances; contacts were needed for effective access and regulatory approvals. The second wave in 2021 saw a similar spike in demand for oxygen and specialized medicines from abroad. Locating, negotiating and contracting supplies became the priority of Indian diplomacy. And it really bent its back to deliver. These examples may be the